

VEER

Claude on Your Phone

The version that's with you when the problem actually happens.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Use it differently on a phone, rather than badly imitating the computer.

Talk instead of typing, where your device offers it.

Use it out in the world — the shop, the appointment, the roadside.

Photograph things on the spot and get an answer standing there.

Move between phone and computer without losing your place.

Know when the phone is the wrong tool and it can wait.

Keep five phone-only moments in mind that are worth more than everything else.

01

What's actually different

The phone isn't a smaller computer for this. It's a different tool, and people who treat it as the same one end up frustrated by the typing and stop.

Three real differences:

Typing is slow. So the phone rewards short asks and voice, and punishes long careful ones.

The screen is small. Long answers are miserable to read. Ask for short ones.

You have it where the problem is. This is the whole advantage, and it's a large one.

That third point is the book. On a computer you use it *about* your life. On a phone you use it *in* your life.

So ask for short answers, deliberately. Add *keep it to a few sentences* — it's the single biggest improvement to phone use, and it should be one of your standing rules from *Making Claude Remember You*.

And do the thinking-heavy work elsewhere. Understanding a contract, comparing quotes, drafting something careful — those are computer tasks. The phone is for the moment you're standing in.

THE REFRAME

Don't ask "what can I do on the phone that I do on the laptop?" Ask "what happens away from my desk that I could never get help with before?" Everything useful in this book comes from that second question.

Try this now. Set a standing rule asking for short answers. You'll feel it immediately.

02

Talking instead of typing

Typing a paragraph on a phone is a chore. Speaking one takes fifteen seconds, and describing a situation out loud tends to produce *better* context than typing it, because people naturally say more.

Where your app offers voice input, use it for exactly the thing this series keeps asking for: the situation, described the way you'd tell a friend.

It doesn't need to be tidy. Half-sentences, changing your mind mid-thought, backing up — all fine. Rambling out loud usually beats a careful typed sentence, because it contains more.

Check it heard you before relying on the answer, particularly with names, numbers and places.

And if your device doesn't offer it, your keyboard's own dictation does the same job. Nothing in this lesson depends on a particular feature existing.

THE BEST USE OF SPEAKING TO IT

Walking. Describing a problem out loud while you walk is a genuinely good way to think, and now something is listening and organising it. Several people find this the single most useful thing on the phone.

Try this now. Describe a problem out loud rather than typing it. Notice how much more you said.

03

Using it out in the world

Standing in a shop, sitting in a waiting room, stuck at the roadside. These are the moments the phone earns its place.

In a shop. *I'm looking at two of these and I can't tell the difference. Here's a photo of both labels.*

In a waiting room. *My appointment is in ten minutes. Help me get my questions in order.*

In an unfamiliar place. *This sign is in Portuguese and I can't read it.*

At the roadside. *This warning light has come on. What is it and is it safe to keep driving?*

In a conversation. Someone mentions something you don't know. Ask quietly, later, without having to admit it.

That last one deserves a mention. A large amount of adult life is nodding at things you don't understand. Being able to ask afterwards, privately, is a small thing with a surprisingly large effect on how much you take in.

THE URGENT ONES ARE STILL NOT FOR THIS

A warning light: yes for "what does this symbol mean." No for whether your brakes are safe. Chest pain, a gas smell, a child who's hurt, anything with a real deadline — that's a phone call to a person, immediately. The phone in your hand is better used for the number than the question.

Try this now. Next time you're waiting somewhere, use the ten minutes rather than scrolling.

04

Photographs, on the spot

Everything in *Photos, Files, and Documents* applies, and the phone is where it comes into its own — because the camera and the question are in the same object.

The moments that come up most:

A label, an ingredients list, a dosage instruction.

A plant, an insect, a mark on a wall, something growing where it shouldn't.

A menu in a language you don't read.

A form someone has handed you.

A part you need to buy and can't name.

The photo rules from No. 10 matter more here, because phone photos are taken quickly in bad light. Get close, steady your hands, and if there's small print, take a second close-up.

Ask it to read back anything where a misread word would matter — a dosage, an allergen, a price.

TWO WHERE BEING WRONG IS EXPENSIVE

Allergens and medicine. Use a photo to help you find and understand the information; then read the label yourself before anyone eats or takes anything. A misread word in poor light looks exactly like a read one.

Try this now. Photograph something with small print, in the light you'd normally be in, and ask it to read it back.

05

Moving between phone and computer

Conversations follow your account rather than your device, which makes a genuinely useful pattern possible.

Start rough on the phone, finish properly at the desk. Describe the problem out loud while it's in front of you, then open the same conversation later on a bigger screen where you can actually read and edit.

Or the reverse. Prepare at the desk, then have the questions with you in the room.

Anything permanent you've set up follows you too — your standing rules and workspaces are on the account, not the device. Set them once on whichever is easier to type on.

THE PATTERN WORTH BUILDING

Capture on the phone, work on the computer. The phone is where you notice things; the desk is where you have the patience to do something with them. Most people find this rhythm within a fortnight and never go back.

Try this now. Start something on your phone. Open it later on a computer. See that it's there.

06

When the phone is the wrong tool

Being honest about this makes the rest more useful.

Wrong for anything long. Reading a summary of a twelve-page document on a phone is worse than not doing it.

Wrong for anything careful. A difficult message deserves a screen where you can see the whole thing before sending. Draft on the phone if you must, send from a desk.

Wrong for comparisons. Two quotes side by side need width.

Wrong when you're rushing. Most bad decisions helped along by a phone were made standing up, in a hurry, wanting an answer rather than the right answer.

That last one is the real warning. The convenience that makes the phone good — an answer wherever you are — is the same property that makes it easy to act on something without checking.

THE PAUSE WORTH TAKING

Before acting on a phone answer, ask whether you'd act on it if you'd read it at a desk. Money, health, anything with a signature — those wait for the bigger screen. Nothing in this book needs to be decided standing up.

Try this now. Think of a decision you made on your phone that you'd have made differently sitting down. Everyone has one.

07

Five things worth doing on a phone and nowhere else

If you take nothing else, take these.

Ask what something is, while you're looking at it. The plant, the label, the warning light, the sign.

Prepare in the ten minutes before, in the waiting room or the car park, rather than wishing you had.

Think out loud while you walk. Describe the problem to something that organises it. Unreasonably effective.

Ask the thing you'd be embarrassed to ask. In the moment, privately, instead of nodding and moving on.

Capture it before it's gone. The idea, the thing someone said, the question you meant to look up. Say it into the phone and deal with it later.

Notice what those five have in common: **none of them is a task.**

They're all moments — things that happen away from a desk, that used to pass unresolved because getting help wasn't practical.

That's the honest case for the phone version. Not that it does more, but that it's there when the thing happens.

THE ONE TO START WITH

The waiting-room one. Ten minutes before an appointment, spent getting your questions in order, changes how the appointment goes more reliably than anything else in this book.

Try this now. Pick one of the five. Use it this week.

Current as of Q3 2026

The only page tied to things that change. Check you have the current edition.

Getting the app. Search your phone's app store for Claude, published by Anthropic. Check the publisher before installing — popular names attract imitators. Sign in with the account you already use; there's nothing to transfer.

Voice. The app has offered voice input, and what it offers has changed over time. If you don't see it, your phone keyboard's own dictation does the same job for everything in Lesson 2 — nothing here depends on a particular feature.

The camera. Attaching a photo normally offers your camera as well as your photo library, so you can take a picture without leaving the conversation.

Across devices. Conversations and any permanent setup live on your account, so they appear on every device you sign in on.

VERIFY BEFORE YOU RELY ON IT

What the app offers, what voice does, and what's included on each plan all change. Check the official source rather than a printed page — including this one.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other six.

Use the ten minutes before an appointment.

In the waiting room, the car park, on the bus. *I'm about to see the doctor about this. Help me get my questions in order, and tell me what I should mention that I might not think of.*

It's the clearest case of the phone's actual advantage: you're not at your desk, you have a few minutes, and the thing you need help with is about to happen. People walk into appointments they'd been dreading for weeks with a list, and come out having asked what they meant to ask.

Nothing else in this book changes an outcome that reliably.

Do this next

Photographing things on the spot? → Photos, Files, and Documents — how to take a picture it can read, and the read-back habit that catches misreadings.

Tired of re-explaining yourself? → Making Claude Remember You — six sentences, set once, that follow you onto every device.

Preparing for appointments? → Family Life — writing the symptom timeline and the questions before you go.

Ideas for the moments in between? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude — open at any page.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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